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Consulting Office (CSC)

Scrum Meetings Guideline

Version 1.1

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Backlog Grooming

Purpose

Prepare draft of Sprint Backlog for optimizing planning meeting; update Product Backlog

Participants

Product Owner, development team, Scrum Master

Duration: 1 - 2 hours, at least once per sprint

Preparation

Make sure that:

- ✓ the meeting is booked in advance
- ✓ the video environment is ready in case of remote Product Owner
- ✓ meeting invitation is sent to all participants
- ✓ Product Backlog is available and initial priorities are set
- ✓ Product Owner joins the meeting

Event Handling

1. Product Owner presents list of top priority stories from Product Backlog assumed to be considered for the next sprint
2. For each story repeat steps 3-7
3. Product Owner presents story and specifies its Acceptance Criteria
4. Team asks questions to understand the story
5. If the team considers a story too big, they suggest breaking it down into smaller pieces
6. If the team identifies a technical task required for completing the story, they suggest adding it to Product Backlog
7. Product Owner sets priorities for newly identified stories
8. Obsolete stories are identified and removed from backlog
9. Duplicate stories are identified and removed from backlog
10. Team reviews initial Sprint Backlog to ensure they got all necessary clarifications and Acceptance Criteria
11. Team estimates complexity of backlog items in Story Points, for example using Planning Poker
12. Sprint Velocity is calculated and compared with average team's Velocity
13. If sprint Velocity is less than average team's Velocity, then Product Owner should add more items to Sprint Backlog.

Don'ts

- don't try to break stories into tasks immediately
- don't run into technical discussions that don't affect estimation of story complexity
- don't hesitate to ask Product Owner to add/breakdown backlog items

Deliverables

- ❑ Preliminary Sprint Backlog ready for planning
- ❑ Updated Product Backlog.

Sprint Planning – Part 1

Purpose

Sprint planning is a meeting for defining the goal of the sprint and what we will deliver by it's end

Duration: 2 hours for 2-week sprint

Participants

Development team, Scrum Master

Preparation

Make sure that:

- ✓ Product Owner prepared the Product Backlog for the sprint (well written, prioritized user stories with or without estimates and explanation how to demonstrate)
- ✓ key participants are invited and everybody knows where and when the meeting is and how long will it take (reminder sent in advance)
- ✓ meeting environment is prepared (room booked, equipment, software and Product Backlog accessible)
- ✓ team members' capacity for the project is clear
- ✓ results of previous sprints are known (capacity, Velocity, Focus Factor)
- ✓ risks and/or impediments are known (vacations, holidays, infrastructure issues etc)
- ✓ person taking notes in the meeting is assigned (if needed).

Event handling

1. Product Owner shares sprint goal with the team
2. Product Owner takes the first Product Backlog item (User Story), sharing his vision/understanding of the user story and its contribution to the goal of the sprint
3. Team asks questions and discusses the story with Product Owner
4. Acceptance Criteria and how to demonstrate the stories is defined
5. Product Owner and team clearly understand the scope of the story and Acceptance Criteria
6. Team estimates required high level effort to complete the story if they are not estimated already (e.g. Story Points via Planning Poker) or agrees on existing estimates (or corrects them if needed)
7. User story put into Sprint Backlog (if there is capacity for this)
8. Repeat steps from 2 to 7 until reach full (or almost full) team capacity for the sprint (if story is too large or epic then agree to move it to the next sprint or split into smaller stories so that one of the split stories can be taken in the sprint and other ones can be postponed till following sprints)
9. Ask the team if they are ready to commit to the work for the sprint, i.e. they believe that they can finish this amount of stories in one sprint
10. Verify that Product Owner agrees with the scope for the sprint.

Don'ts

- don't plan iterations without team and Product Owner (or clear input from Product Owner)
- don't commit to user stories that the team do not fully understand and which PO can't explain clearly
- don't let the team commit to user stories without estimates or change prioritization
- don't let the team members get involved in detailed design/architecture discussions → just enough to understand what is needed to build (check if the discussion affects estimate for the story).
- don't split stories into tasks (and don't estimate tasks… yet ☺)

Deliverables

- ❑ Sprint goal that is clear to everyone
- ❑ Sprint Backlog with selected stories

Sprint Planning – Part 2

Purpose

Define estimated list of tasks needed to implement all the backlog items from the Sprint Backlog

Duration: 2 hours for 2-week sprint

Participants

Development team, Scrum Master

Preparation

Make sure that:

- ✓ Sprint goal and Sprint Backlog are defined
- ✓ key participants invited, and everybody knows where and when the meeting is and how long will it take (reminder sent in advance)
- ✓ capacity is known for each team member
- ✓ meeting room is prepared (room booked, equipment, software and Sprint Backlog accessible)

Event handling

1. Team takes the first Sprint Backlog item
2. Team specifies tasks needed to implement the chosen story
3. Team estimates the tasks in hours taking into account votes of potential assignees
4. If a task is estimated at more than 8 hours then team is asked to split it into smaller tasks
5. The team takes the next backlog item and repeats steps 2 to 4 until the end of the Sprint Backlog
6. Team calculates the total effort estimate in hours for the Sprint Backlog
7. Team calculates their capacity for the sprint in hours considering focus-factor (if known or use 0.5)
8. Total estimate is compared with team capacity:
   - If the team is underloaded they can ask the Product Owner to add some more work into the Sprint Backlog and repeat steps 2 to 4
   - If the team is overloaded then the Product Owner may remove work from the Sprint Backlog
10. The team must have a clear understanding on how to do it
11. The team confirms commitment to deliver backlog items taken into the sprint
12. A Task Board (stickers, tools etc.) and Burndown chart arranged.

Don'ts

- don't allow one team member (team lead, lead developer etc.) to estimate and/or assign all tasks by themselves
- don't allow technical discussions that don't affect the estimation.

Deliverables

- ❑ Sprint Backlog with tasks estimated in hours
- ❑ Sprint taskboard and the initial Burndown are ready.

Daily Stand Up

Purpose

Synchronize team plan for the day and identify blockers; track team progress

Participants

Development team, Scrum Master, Product Owner (optional)

Duration: 15-minutes, timeboxed, daily

Preparation

Make sure that:

- ✓ meeting is booked in advance at the same time, same place
- ✓ meeting invitation is sent to all participants
- ✓ visuals are ready and available: Task Board, Burndown
- ✓ team has updated Task Board including task statuses and remaining time

Event Handling

1. Connect all participants in a single conference call or get together in a dedicated place
2. Open and share Task Board
3. Each team member answers 3 questions:
    - What have I done since yesterday
    - What will I do today?
    - What impediments do I have?
4. If needed/possible update task statuses on Task Board on the go
5. Scrum Master writes down all identified impediments
6. Responsible persons decided for resolving every impediment:
    - team members for internal issues
    - Scrum Master for external ones
7. If unplanned task is identified then assigned team member takes responsibility to estimate and update it on the Task Board
8. If an urgent issue is brought by Product Owner then schedule separate meeting after the Stand Up for clarification and re-planning.

Additional hints:

9. Open Burndown and check if team is on track
10. If team is not on track, make sure there is an action plan for impediments and discuss re-planning with Product Owner if needed.

Don’ts

- don’t set a meeting time inconvenient for team members
- don’t report to the Scrum Master only, but to the whole team
- don’t disrupt everyone’s attention by arriving late, taking calls, or having side discussions on non-work topics
- don’t report about stories using ID only
- don’t spend the whole team’s time discussing details not interesting to everyone
- don’t talk in too much detail on technical solutions
- don’t let the Scrum Master update task statuses/move cards on the Task Board instead of team members
- don’t try to resolve impediments immediately.

Deliverables

- ❑ Task Board and Burndown updated with actual status
- ❑ list of impediments with assignees.

Sprint Review

Purpose

Accept completed backlog items and identify incomplete ones. If possible, get feedback from users or stakeholders about working software and verify the direction with achievements towards plans

Duration: 30 - 90 minutes, depending on team size and team setup (distributed or colocated)

Participants

Development team, Scrum Master, Product Owner, stakeholders, end users

Preparation

Make sure that:

- ✓ the meeting is booked in advance
- ✓ the meeting invitation is sent to all participants and location is stated in the invitation (if necessary)
- ✓ a stable version of the working software is ready to be shown
- ✓ the team is updated in advance all statuses and time remaining for tasks so that it can be clearly understandable what is finished and what is not
- ✓ all necessary visuals are ready and available: Burndown, Definition of done etc.

Event Handling

1. Connect all participants in a single conference call or get together in a dedicated place
2. Open and/or share Task Board
3. Agree on the question “was the sprint goal achieved or not?” or “was the sprint successful or not?”
4. Open the Sprint Backlog on a backlog item level (filter out technical sub-tasks if needed)
5. Take a backlog item and agree on the answer to the question, “is it completed?”

   *Hint: the order can vary - by item’s position in the Sprint Backlog, by assignee etc.
6. If you agreed that the Sprint Backlog item was fully completed, demonstrate the results on a demo environment
7. If not - decide what to do (e.g. mo,ve to the next sprint, move to the Product Backlog, close as obsolete)
8. Repeat steps 5 - 7 until you have all planned Sprint Backlog items passed one by one
9. Update statistics (Velocity calculation, identify if backlog items significantly differ from original estimation, record feedback about each backlog item).

Don’ts

- don’t forget about technical backlog items if they should be demonstrated and this is technically possible
- don’t forget to demonstrate improvements planned for the sprint (code review practice, unit tests, strict adherence to DoD etc.)
- don’t demonstrate incomplete backlog items
- don’t use the Scrum Master as the presenter of accomplished work
- don’t make it as a formal report to the PO
- don’t start discussing/solving problems immediately (keep your ideas for the retrospective meeting).

Deliverables

- ❑ Clear list of accepted backlog Items
- ❑ Understanding of what could be demonstrated to users/stakeholders
- ❑ Understanding of what could be deployed to production (if needed/possible)
- ❑ Decisions on what to do with incomplete backlog Items
- ❑ Input for updating Product Backlog (new backlog items, updates on backlog items, obsolete backlog items).

Retrospective

Purpose

Develop improvement plan.

Duration: 1 - 3 hours, timeboxed, at the end of iteration
- depends on team size
- depends on length of iteration

Participants

Development team, Scrum Master,
Product Owner (optional)

Preparation

Make sure that:

- ✓ the meeting booked in advance in a separate room
- ✓ the video conference booked for distributed participants
- ✓ the meeting invitation is sent out to all participants
- ✓ the retrospective format is chosen (6 steps, Star fish, Learning Matrix etc.)
- ✓ statistical data is ready and available: Burndown, Velocity, actual Focus Factor, planned vs. accomplished items, unplanned items added during sprint, number of found issues etc.
- ✓ stationery is available: post-it notes, pens, markers, whiteboard, flipchart or paper
- ✓ a visualization tool is chosen and set up in case of distributed participants
- ✓ screen sharing started in case of distributed participants
- ✓ templates available if using a specific format

Event Handling

1. Set the stage, for example ask everyone to briefly comment on their feelings regarding the last iteration. Make sure everyone is ready to speak up
2. Create a timeline by collecting major events from the team, written as one event per post-it or virtual card
3. Collect well-done items from each team member
4. Collect need-to-improve items from each team-members
3. Divide need-to-improve items into 2 categories:
   - those the team can resolve by themselves
   - those requiring organizational involvement
4. Selects the most important points for improvement, for example using the “dot vote” technique or any other way of prioritization
5. Perform root-cause analysis on major improvement points
6. Generate and write down ideas on actions for selected improvement points
7. Generate detailed action plan if more than one step required
8. Assign responsible person for each action Item:
   - team member if it can be resolved by the team
   - Scrum Master or Product Owner if organizational involvement is required
9. Set deadline for each action Item (for example current/next sprint date)
10. Create backlog item when a significant amount of time is needed for an action item
11. Close retrospective
12. Discuss on changing retrospective format

Don’ts

- don’t use the retrospective as reporting or “scapegoat" seeking tool
- don’t make it too often, once per 2-4 weeks
- don’t make it too rarely
- don’t skip or postpone – being distributed is not an excuse
- don’t take too many points for improvement (have up to 3 points)
- don’t forget to facilitate properly
- don’t let the facilitator focus on his/her ideas rather than on the group dynamic and agenda
- don’t ignore distributed members or let them stay silent
- don’t invite external people, it will restrict openness and team members will not participate properly
- don’t invite higher management unless team really needs them for discussion
- don’t point at or push people
- don’t forget to assign an owner for each improvement step
- don’t forget about deadlines for actions
- don’t forget to book time for work on improvements in the next sprint
- don’t focus only on negative or positive topics; instead of "what was bad" ask “what we could improve?"
- don’t wait for the retrospective if you have an urgent issue in the sprint
- don’t disturb the team with something that could wait until the retrospective.

Deliverables

- ❑ List of points for improvements with action plan for each point, including assignee and deadline for each item.

About Consulting Office

Who are our clients

Ongoing **25**

active engagements with our clients during a month

Countries **12**

Denmark, Sweden, Norway, Germany, the Netherlands, UK, Switzerland, France, Estonia, USA, Canada and New Zealand

1500+
monthly hours

300+
people consulted monthly

What about our team

Consultants **23**

highly professional and skilled specialists eager to help you to boost your business

Our locations **6**

locations where our consultants are based in Ukraine (Kyiv, Kharkiv, Dnepropetrovsk, Vinnytsia and Odessa) and in Belarus (Minsk)

Dev Teams **170**

our consultants have access for hands-on experience to more than 170 development teams

About Consulting Office

How we do our work

- Management (51%)
- Nearshore (26%)
- Onshore (23%)

Products **10+**

more than 10 consulting products aimed to take your processes to the ultimate level:

- Agile Injection
- DevOps Injection
- Product Ownership
- ICAgile Certification
- Comparative Agility Measurment System (CAMS)
- Agile Testing

and many more...